

Why should you allow an initiative to have currently non-quantifiable outcomes?

People often demand that outcomes in a strategy/outcomes diagram or outcomes framework only include currently quantifiable boxes. For instance, the widely used SMART acronym for well-formed objectives insists that objectives need to be 'Specific, Measurable, Achievable, Relevant and Time-based'. From a technical perspective, it's a mistake to limit yourself only to currently quantifiable steps and outcomes in an outcomes framework. The Including Currently Non-Quantifiable Steps and Outcomes in Strategy/Outcomes Diagrams and Outcomes Frameworks Tip (B15) explains why.

First, adopting a measurables-only approach to specifying outcomes means that during strategic discussions about an agency, provider, policy, or initiative's work, there is no formal way of considering not currently quantifiable outcomes. You are therefore likely to miss strategic risks and opportunities as you have no proper way of identifying, communicating, and talking about them.

Second, sticking with just what you can currently measure can stifle innovation. Measuring and quantifying things costs money. What we measure today reflects what we were interested in yesterday and therefore what we invested in measuring yesterday. At least some of the time when innovating, we will likely be doing things for which we have not yet created measures. Therefore, if we want to encourage innovation, it is important that we allow currently non-quantified outcomes within a strategy/outcomes diagram or outcomes framework. Outcomes frameworks (like those built according to SMART) that do not have a place for the currently non-quantified are less likely to encourage innovation.

Third, measurement is essential, but the time to introduce measurement is AFTER you have built your DoView strategy/outcomes diagram or framework. This is done by simply going through the diagram looking at each box and asking the question: 'can we measure this box?'. This is a much more effective way of identifying Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) and other indicators than the traditional approach of trying to do this without the benefit of a strategy/outcomes diagram. See the Putting Indicators Onto a DoView Strategy Diagram Tool (D4) for how to do this.

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